the ground floor three months before December 2023."

The grandness of the project is not in question—the height from the ground to the top will be 181 feet; the ground floor will extend 380 feet in the east-west direction and 250 feet from north to south. White marble from Rajasthan's Makrana hills will be used in the *garbha griha* (sanctum sanctorum). "Some of the carved marble has already reached Ayodhya," says an official of the trust, on condition of anonymity.

At least 40 per cent of the temple has already been built, say sources. The construction work on the three-floor superstructure comprising the *garbha griha* and five *mandap*s (porches), the pilgrimage facilitation centre, other utilities and infrastructure services in the complex has also started. The trust hopes to have the Ramlalla idol installed in the *garbha griha* and the temple opened for darshan by December 2023. "The foundation has been laid, and the plinth or the pedestal-raising work, which began on January 24 this year, is going on," says the trust official. On a more specific note, a source from the Vishva Hindu Parishad, who does not wish to be named, says *darshan* will begin from Makar Sankranti in January 2024. The temple in its entirety, though, will be ready only by 2025.

The construction committee, along with the engineers and architects, meets every month for two to three days under the chairmanship of Nripendra Misra, former principal secretary to the prime minister, and takes stock of the progress of the work. Chandrakant B. Sompura, who has designed 131 temples along with son Ashish, including the Swaminarayan temple in Gandhinagar and the Ambaji temple in Palanpur in Gujarat, is the architect for the main temple. Jay Kaktikar of Design Associates, who has designed most of former Uttar Pradesh chief minister Mayawati's projects, is the architect for the remaining areas of the complex, including temples for Rishi Valmiki, Acharya Vasishtha, Rishi Vishwamitra, Agastya Muni, Nishad, Jatayu and Mata Sabri. The masterplan for where each of these will be located in the complex is being finalised, says a source in the trust.

Originally estimated to cost Rs 1,100 crore, technical changes, expansion of the temple complex and rising cost of land acquisition have pushed the estimate to Rs 1,800 crore. And not just the temple complex, the entire heritage town is getting a makeover.

THE TEMPLE WILL BE OPENED TO THE PUBLIC ONCE THE RAMLALLA IDOL IS INSTALLED IN THE GARBHA GRIHA, WHICH SOURCES EXPECT TO TAKE PLACE BY DEC. '23. DARSHAN IS LIKELY TO BEGIN FROM MAKAR SANKRANTI IN JAN. 2024

REVAMP MENU

Besides the Ram temple, several infrastructure projects promise to change the face of the pilgrim town



RAM TEMPLE

Budget: ₹**1,800** crore
Deadline: Construction of ground floor should get completed three months before December 2023. Darshan will begin after installing the Ramlalla idol in the sanctum sanctorum. The full temple should be ready by 2025
Status: Construction on in full swing

MARYADA PURUSHOTTAM SHRIRAM AIRPORT

Budget: ₹**525** crore
Deadline: Air strip to be finished by December 2022, Terminal 1 by March 2023
Status: Phase 1 progressing fast

RAILWAY STATION

Budget: ₹**350** crore
Deadline: First phase to be finished by December 2022
Status: Phase 1 is expected to be functional by the end of this year



NAVYA AYODHYA, 1,500-ACRE VASTU-FRIENDLY TOWNSHIP

Budget: ₹**10,000** crore
Deadline: Final vision to be completed by 2047
Status: At various stages of construction